THE TARANG PROGRAMME

Tarang Transforming Schools Project 2017- 2019

The Tarang Transforming Schools Project (TTSP) represents Sethu's work in the field of inclusive education for over 13 years. The objective of the project at its start in 2006, was capacity building of preschool teachers. With this aim in mind, the Sethu team conducted various 8 month teacher training programmes over several years. However, it was apparent that training often failed to translate to better teaching practices in the classroom. One possible reason was the fact that teachers were trained in isolation, without involving the Heads and Management of the schools where they worked. The Sethu team realised that change can happen only if teachers and management work together with a shared vision. This led to the development of the TTSP in 2017. This was aimed at training both principals and teachers bringing them onto a common platform and support each other in the process of positive change. The TTSP was implemented over a period of 2 years in a series of steps with 11 preschools.

The objectives of the TTSP were:

1. To train principals and teachers of pre-schools in Goa in the 3 Ps of inclusivity: **philosophy**, **policy** and **practices**.
2. To work collaboratively with these preschools to strengthen their own policies and practices in inclusive education.
3. To host a state level symposium to share the experiences of our findings.
4. To develop a manual documenting how to implement evidence-based strategies for inclusion in preschools.

First Year: Capacity Building (2017- 2018)

Sethu is fortunate to have many years of experience interacting with preschools in a variety of ways. Many schools refer children with challenges in learning or behavior for assessment and therapy at Sethu. The team regularly visits preschools to offer on-site advice to teachers on child development and behavior. Sethu staff conduct training sessions for teachers several times every year and have built good relationships with a host of schools. Hence we decided to start with the schools where we have already built bridges of support and inclusion.

a) **1 Day: Orientation**

Invitations to participate in the TTSP were sent out to 40 preschools in North and South Goa. These were schools that admitted children with special needs and had previously referred them for evaluation to Sethu. Each school head was requested to attend the session, together with one senior teacher. 22 schools accepted the invitation and attended the 1-day Orientation Session which introduced the participants to the core concepts of inclusion such as diversity, attitude change and the need for accommodation and adaptation for disability. The participants were also informed about the more intensive training programmes (details below) planned for the upcoming academic year. They were asked to register their school for the year-long collaboration and training if they were keen to join hands with Sethu in the journey to inclusion. 13 schools signed up for the one year programme.

b) **2 Day: Leadership for Inclusion Training**

The follow up to the orientation session was a 2 day training session for principals of preschools. 13 Heads of Schools attended this session in which they were acquainted with the concept of inclusive philosophy, policy and practice for their schools. This was done by familiarising them with the checklist on Indicators for Excellence in Inclusive Education (Appendix 1). This comprehensive evaluation form would be used to review and rate their schools. Principals were also given an overview of the eight training modules that their teachers would receive during the academic year. The critical leadership role of the principal was highlighted throughout the session.

c) **Certificate course in Inclusive Education for Teachers** - 25 teachers from 11 preschools in North and South Goa attended 8 sessions which were conducted on a monthly basis over one academic year. The training topics included were:

i. Multiple Intelligences and Curriculum Based Assessment
ii. Universal Design for Learning
iii. Language and Reading
iv. Pathways to Numeracy
v. Behavior Management in the Classroom
vi. Sequenced Guidelines to Develop Handwriting.
vii. Including Children through Art and Physical Education
viii. Disability and Inclusion

At the end of each module teachers were required to submit one practical assignment based on the input received in that session.

d) **School Visits**: To assess the impact of the training in facilitating better inclusive environments in the partner schools, the project team visited the schools four times over the school year. On their first visit, the team observed lessons, classroom structure, and the general routine of the school day. During the next visit, the team along with the principal rated the school on the Indicators for Excellence in Inclusive Education (IEIE). This joint exercise allowed the principals to focus on and select areas for improvement in philosophy, policy and practice in their own schools. Thus, an attitude of reflection and self evaluation was encouraged. The remaining two visits were conducted during the rest of the year to observe how teachers were implementing various aspects of their training.

e) **Joint Meeting between Principals and Teachers**: This meeting was conducted at the end of the year in which principals and teachers of the school sat together and drew up joint goals in the areas of philosophy, policy and practice based on the IEIE. The emphasis was on the joint action between principals and teachers so that members of both groups were aware of the changes that needed to take place in order to make their schools more inclusive. This meeting also served as a forum for discussion of the challenges faced by the teachers in the classroom, the administrative challenges faced by the principals with respect to policy and management as well as providing peer support.

Second Year: Mentorship (2018 – 2019)

The second year was considered as the mentorship year in which various members of the Sethu team worked with principals and teachers on-site in their own schools to further strengthen inclusive policies and practices

a) **Visits to schools:** Sethu staff visited the preschools to observe teaching practices, troubleshoot various problems, ensure that training was maintained through ongoing support, and that principals and teachers were working toward the goals that they had set in the previous year. The visits focused on the following areas of development.

   i) Adopting a developmentally appropriate curriculum in the areas of reading, language, maths and handwriting

   ii) Helping the teachers deliver lessons using the format of the Universal Design for Learning

   iii) Guiding the principals of schools towards written policy changes which are more inclusive in nature

   iv) Assisting teachers develop classrooms that used positive behavior supports

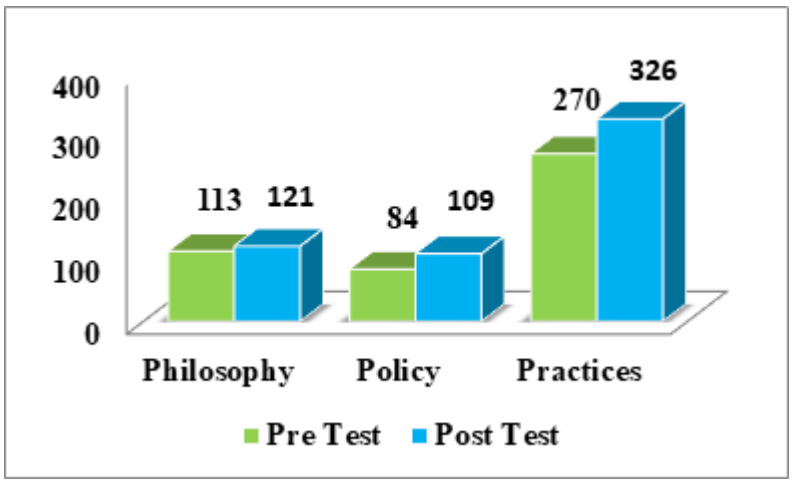
   v) Helping teachers use existing supports more effectively to work with children with special needs

b) 3 day Teacher Training Programme: Many principals expressed the need for other teachers in their schools to be trained in addition to the teachers who had attended the 8 month TTSP. Therefore a 3 day training based on the core practices of the 8 month programme was organised for those teachers who had not participated. Two training sessions (one for teachers in North Goa and one for

teachers in South Goa) over three days each, were conducted. Teachers received training in Universal Design for Learning, language and reading, pathways to numeracy, behaviour management in the classroom and sequenced guidelines to develop handwriting.

Results: At the end of the first year 3 schools opted out of mentorship. Some of the reasons cited were difficulty in adopting a developmentally appropriate curriculum and difficulty in planning lessons in UDL format. 8 schools signed on for the second year of mentoring. Unfortunately, towards the middle of the second year another school dropped out due to lack of support from the management. By the end of the second year seven schools remained onboard. The various changes that took place in these seven schools are documented below. For more details refer to the bar graph.

Indicators for Excellence in Inclusive education: The IEIE checklist was scored before the start of the programme and at the end and average scores before and after the intervention were compared. All schools showed positive changes in philosophy, policy and practice with increased scores after implementation. The change in the average scores across all the 7 schools are shown in the bar graph.



Changes in Philosophy: 7 out of the 8 schools displayed varying levels of attitudinal change. This change was reflected in the desire to

a) Have sensitisation workshops for parents

b) Make changes to their vision and mission statements

c) Send all teachers for additional training

d) Convey to the community at large that the school actively welcomes children with special needs

Changes in Policy: At the beginning of the programme, most of the schools shared that they welcomed children with special needs however no schools had clearly stated this as part of their written policy. After the training, 4 out of the 8 schools have made changes in their written policies. Some examples of these include:

a) Stating that the school welcomes children with special needs in the school prospectus and calendar

b) Putting 'Inclusive Education' on the agenda for discussion at staff meetings

c) Celebrating one day annually as 'Inclusion Day' in the school

d) Instituting one mandatory annual training in inclusive education for the entire staff

Changes in Practice: All 8 schools showed changes in practices. Examples of these are listed below:

a) **Adoption of a developmentally appropriate curriculum.** At the beginning of the TTSP, only four out of the eight schools had written curricula for maths and writing. Two of these four schools also had a curriculum for reading. No school had a separate curriculum for language. None of these curricula were developmentally appropriate. After reviewing the curricula of the schools, the Sethu team developed developmentally sequenced preschool curricula in reading, writing, maths and language. The objective was to ensure meaningful learning through developmentally appropriate and sequenced concepts and prepare children for Std. 1 after 3-4 years of preschool. Five of the eight preschools adopted Sethu's developmentally appropriate curriculum in reading, language, writing and maths.

b) **Change in Lesson Plans to UDL Format**: Six out of eight schools have adopted the UDL lesson planning format. Lesson plans were printed in the UDL format to ensure that teachers write their lesson plans in this format.

c) **Teacher Support:** In many cases teachers feel overwhelmed by the number of students in the classroom and coping with two or three children with special needs becomes even more challenging. Three principals have acknowledged that the teachers need support to work with children with disabilities and have provided them with part-time or full-time assistants in the classroom. Teachers have also learned to use

their assistants to work with children in the classroom rather than sending them to a resource room.

d) **Case Study Discussions during Staff Meetings**: Four out of the eight schools have added the discussion of children with special needs to the agenda of staff meetings. This allows teachers to share success stories as well as challenges thus offering peer support and creating a feeling of working as a team.

The Road Forward: While all schools have shown changes in philosophy, policy and practice there is still more to be done to strengthen inclusion. Some areas for further improvement are suggested below.

a) **Involvement of Other Stakeholders**: This project focused on only two of the stakeholders in schools viz. principals and teachers. At the end of two years it was clear that the school as a whole will continue to require ongoing support in the form of training and sensitising many other stakeholders like parents, non-teaching staff, school management and possibly the community so that the children with special needs are supported at all levels.

b) Appointment of a Coordinator for Inclusive Education: There is also a need to identify persons in the school who will actively take on the duties of a coordinator to oversee all aspects of inclusive education while ensuring that the gains made in terms of policy and practice are taken forward. Currently this role is often performed by principals who are also in charge of the entire school (primary, middle and high school sections). This makes it very difficult for them to actively attend to

matters in the preschool. This is especially important in the area of curriculum development and behaviour management issues.

It is abundantly clear that inclusive education can be successfully implemented when there is a holistic and systemic approach involving all stakeholders in the schools.
